

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN MAURITANIA

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

This guide must begin honestly, because Mauritania is a hard place to oppose a project and there is no landmark community victory to point to. Mauritania's economy runs on extraction: state-owned iron ore in the north, a vast foreign-owned gold mine near the coast, and a new offshore gas field, together with the industrial fishing that presses on one of the world's great bird and fish sanctuaries, the **Banc d'Arguin**. When communities and workers have pushed back — as when hundreds of workers laid off from the Tasiast gold mine travelled three hundred kilometres to protest outside the presidential palace, only to have their camp raided by police, with a dozen arrested and others injured — the state has more often answered with force than with concession. Civil society is thin and constrained, environmental governance is weak, and the great projects are powerful, foreign-financed, and closely tied to the government's revenues. This guide will not pretend a grassroots win exists where it does not. But there is a real, if modest, distinctive lever, and it is external.

Because Mauritania's great projects are largely foreign-owned and internationally financed, a community has access to international levers of accountability that domestic channels, on their own, do not provide — and the safest, strongest work runs through them. The **international-finance performance standards and the financiers' safeguards** — World Bank guarantees, the international lenders' standards — carry accountability mechanisms a community can invoke, as Tasiast's international financing does. A **foreign owner answers to laws and expectations abroad** — Canadian, British — that reach where local law is weak. The **Banc d'Arguin World Heritage status** is an international lever against harm to the sanctuary near which the projects press. The **transparency initiatives** — the extractive-revenue regimes Mauritania belongs to — open the books. And the **domestic environmental law and assessment**, weak as they are, remain a formal gate. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. Opposition in Mauritania is hard, constrained, and can be met with repression: protest has been raided and protesters arrested; civil society operates under real limits; assessments have been criticised as inadequate or not independent; and the economy's dependence on extraction gives the government and the companies great leverage. The honest record is one of labour disputes and grievances met with force, toxic incidents, and projects that proceed — not of communities stopping mines. So the work must be documentary, international, collective, and protected — preferring the international channels, which are both safer and stronger, to exposed domestic action; never letting a single named person carry a public burden that could make them a target; and using collective and international voice. And no landmark victory is to be won. So the honest prize is accountability, mitigation, and — rarely — a stop, wrung from the financiers, the foreign owners, the UNESCO status, and the transparency regimes, as safely and effectively as the hard conditions allow. Above all, protect the people.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot rely on domestic channels alone in a constrained state that answers protest with force. What you can do is reach the international levers a foreign-financed project actually answers to: the financiers' performance standards and their accountability mechanisms, the foreign owner's home-country laws and expectations, the Banc d'Arguin World Heritage status, and the transparency regimes — pursued documentarily, collectively, and safely, preferring the international channels to exposed domestic action, and

protecting everyone involved.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Mauritania is among the harder settings in this guide, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. Opposition is constrained and can be met with repression — a raided camp, arrests, injuries; civil society is thin; assessments are weak; and the economy's extraction-dependence gives the government and companies great leverage. The honest record is of grievances met with force and projects that proceed, not of communities stopping mines. So the realistic aim is accountability, mitigation, and — rarely — a stop, wrung from the external levers, pursued safely, collectively, and internationally, and protecting everyone.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power rests with a constrained state closely tied to the extractive revenues, but the decisions a community can reach run largely through the projects' external masters: the **international financiers** — the World Bank and lenders whose standards the projects accept; the **foreign owners** — the Canadian and British companies answerable abroad; the **UNESCO World Heritage system** guarding the Banc d'Arguin; the **transparency regimes** Mauritania belongs to; and, formally, the **domestic environment authorities and their assessment**. Map who a project truly answers to abroad before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A mine, gas field, or fishing operation proceeds with state backing, foreign ownership, and international finance, and — formally — a domestic environmental assessment. The entry points are the financiers' performance standards and accountability mechanisms, the foreign owner's home-country obligations, the Banc d'Arguin status where the harm nears the sanctuary, and the transparency regimes. Enter through these international levers, which are safer and stronger, and through the domestic assessment where it exists — documentarily and collectively.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the finance: which international lenders and guarantees back the project, and what performance standards they impose. Follow the ownership: which foreign company owns it, and what laws and expectations it answers to at home. Follow the sanctuary: whether the harm nears the Banc d'Arguin World Heritage site. Follow the revenues: what the transparency regimes reveal. The leverage lies in the financiers' standards, the home-country obligations, the UNESCO status, and the transparency.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is weak and constrained, but the international financiers and their accountability mechanisms, the foreign owners' home-country regulators and expectations, the UNESCO World Heritage system, and the transparency regimes are the watchers a community can reach. These external watchers, not the domestic ones alone, are where the real, safer leverage lies.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Mauritanian community easily stops a foreign-financed extractive project, and honesty requires saying so — the record is of grievances met with force and projects that proceed. What the external levers can deliver

is accountability, mitigation, and, rarely, a stop. The single most decisive move is **reaching the international levers a foreign-financed project answers to — the financiers' standards, the home-country obligations, the UNESCO status**, because these are both safer than exposed domestic action and stronger, reaching where local law is weak. The financiers' standards are the distinctive lever; the home-country obligations the reach; the Banc d'Arguin status the sanctuary's shield; the transparency the openness. The realistic prize is accountability and mitigation, pursued safely and collectively.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the mine, the gas field, the fishing, and what it takes from the land, water, or catch. **Who finances and owns it?** — the international lenders, the foreign company, and their standards and home-country obligations. **Does it near the sanctuary?** — the Banc d'Arguin, and its World Heritage status. **What do the transparency regimes show?** — the revenues and the books. **How is everyone kept safe?** — the overriding question, answered by preferring international channels and protecting individuals. Pick the fight where an external lever — a financier, a foreign owner, the UNESCO status — gives the clearest, safest handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, documentarily and safely. **Layer one: the harm** — what the project takes and pollutes, documented rigorously, with the toxic incidents and the assessment's inadequacies. **Layer two: the standards and the status** — the financiers' performance standards, the foreign owner's home-country obligations, the Banc d'Arguin World Heritage status, the transparency records the harm breaches or strains. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which financier, home-country regulator, or international body to reach, and the discipline of preferring international channels, protecting individuals, and never exposing a single person. A documentary case built on the external standards is one that reaches where domestic pressure cannot, and safely.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: what the mine, gas field, or fishing takes and pollutes, the toxic incidents, the inadequate assessment. Gather the **standards record**: the financiers' performance standards, the foreign owner's home-country obligations, the international-finance terms. Gather the **sanctuary record**: the Banc d'Arguin World Heritage status and any harm nearing it. Gather the **transparency record**: the extractive-revenue disclosures. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm the work prefers international channels, is collective, and exposes no individual.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE COLLECTIVE AND INTERNATIONAL COALITION

The coalition here is collective, protected, and international, because exposed domestic action is dangerous. Build it from the **affected communities and workers**, whose grievance is real but who must never be individually exposed; the **international civil society, watchdogs, and human-rights and environmental organisations** abroad; the **financiers' accountability mechanisms and the foreign owners' home-country advocates**; and the **UNESCO and transparency bodies**. Frame everything collectively and

internationally; never let a single named person carry a public burden that could make them a target; and protect everyone involved absolutely.

STEP 4: THE FINANCIERS, THE FOREIGN OWNERS & THE UNESCO STATUS — REACHING THE EXTERNAL LEVERS

Set expectations honestly: the levers are external, real, and safer than domestic action, but constrained, so the prize is accountability and mitigation, rarely a stop.

The Financiers' Standards

The distinctive lever is the **international-finance performance standards and the financiers' safeguards** — the World Bank guarantees and lenders' standards a project accepts, carrying accountability mechanisms a community can invoke, as Tasiast's international financing does. Bring the documented harm to the financiers' own standards and mechanisms.

The Foreign Owners' Home Countries

A **foreign owner answers to laws and expectations abroad** — Canadian, British — that reach where local law is weak. Bring the harm to the home-country regulators, investors, and advocates who can hold the company to account at its source.

The Banc d'Arguin Status and the Transparency Regimes

The **Banc d'Arguin World Heritage status** is an international lever against harm to the sanctuary, and the **transparency initiatives** open the extractive revenues. Pursued together — the financiers' standards, the home-country obligations, the UNESCO status, and the transparency — these external levers wring accountability and mitigation where domestic pressure cannot, and more safely.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each external audience. **For the financiers:** here is a project breaching your performance standards, with the documented harm. **For the foreign owner's home country:** here is a company failing the laws and expectations it answers to abroad. **For UNESCO:** here is harm nearing the Banc d'Arguin World Heritage sanctuary. **For the transparency regimes:** here are the revenues and books to open. **For the international public:** here is the harm and the accountability owed. **The golden rule:** reach the external levers the project answers to, document rigorously, prefer the international channels, keep everything collective, and never expose a single person.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with care in a state that meets protest with force, and largely through international channels. Frame the story around **the harm and the external accountability:** a foreign-financed project failing its financiers' standards or its owner's home-country obligations, or harm nearing a World Heritage sanctuary — carried through the international press, watchdogs, and advocacy. A few cautions govern everything: never expose an individual; prefer international to domestic exposure; keep it collective; frame it around the documented harm and the external standards; and let the financiers' standards and the UNESCO status carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message documentary, collective, international, and protective of everyone.

8A — To an international financier: set out the project's breach of your performance standards, with the documented harm.

8B — To a foreign owner's home-country regulator or investors: flag the company failing the laws and expectations it answers to abroad.

8C — To UNESCO: document harm nearing the Banc d'Arguin World Heritage sanctuary.

8D — To a transparency initiative: request scrutiny of the extractive revenues and books.

8E — To the domestic environment authority: challenge the inadequate assessment, collectively.

8F — To an international watchdog or advocacy body: share the documented case and request support.

8G — To the affected community: coordinate collectively and safely, exposing no individual.

8H — To the international public: summarise the harm and the accountability owed — collectively, without naming anyone at risk.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: identify the project's financiers and foreign owner and their standards; document the harm; check whether it nears the Banc d'Arguin. **The fastest-moving levers:** the financiers' accountability mechanisms, the foreign owner's home-country channels, and the UNESCO status. **Emergency action:** bring the documented harm to the financiers' mechanism or the home-country regulator — safer and stronger than exposed domestic action. Throughout, keep it collective and international, and expose no individual.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but hard and repressive: a state closely tied to extractive revenues that meets protest with force. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not a domestic stop, but accountability and mitigation through the external levers. Lean on what the tilt cannot reach: the financiers' standards, the foreign owners' home-country obligations, the UNESCO status, the transparency regimes. And accept the honest limits — opposition is dangerous, assessments weak, projects proceed — while still pursuing the external accountability, and protecting everyone.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary tilt from capture — revenues steered to insiders, assessments compromised, projects favoured over communities and the sanctuary. Pursuing accountability where it touches corruption carries real risk, so respond only through the **external and protected channels:** the financiers' anti-corruption and accountability mechanisms, the foreign owners' home-country laws, the transparency regimes, the international watchdogs. Never through exposed domestic confrontation. **On safety and care:** this is the guide's most important note. Mauritania has met protest with force — a raided camp, arrests, injuries — and pursuing accountability carries real risk. Keep the effort documentary, international,

collective, and protected; prefer the international channels, which are safer and stronger; never let a single named person carry a public burden that could make them a target; and protect everyone. Protection is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, externally and safely. The documented harm feeds the financiers' mechanism, the home-country channel, and the UNESCO and transparency appeals at once; the collective and international coalition organises alongside, exposing no one; any attention runs largely through international channels. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm and identify the financiers, owners, and standards; **months two to six**, bring the case to the financiers' mechanisms, the home-country regulators, UNESCO, and the transparency regimes; **beyond**, press the accountability and mitigation. The core discipline: external, documentary, collective, and protective of everyone.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Mauritania is among the harder and more constrained grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a community can readily stop a foreign-financed extractive project, or that opposition is safe, or that a landmark victory exists — none of that is true, and the state has met protest with force. What it claims is narrower and real: that because Mauritania's great projects are foreign-owned and internationally financed, a community can reach the external levers they answer to — the financiers' performance standards and accountability mechanisms, the foreign owners' home-country laws and expectations, the Banc d'Arguin World Heritage status, and the transparency regimes — which are both safer than exposed domestic action and stronger, reaching where local law is weak. The levers are external, and the prize is accountability, mitigation, and — rarely — a stop, not a swift domestic victory. For a constrained state whose biggest projects answer to foreign owners, financiers, and international bodies, that careful, external, collective work — protecting everyone and exposing no one — is not a lesser ambition. It is the responsible and effective one.